plans'.[13] Nevertheless, the number of airborne alerted B-52s increased from twelve to sixty-six, as the aircraft flew to their designated 'Fail-Safe' positions (from which they would return if they did not receive the 'go-code' authorising them to attack). This will be familiar to those who have watched *Dr Strangelove,*where a key part of the plot revolves around a B-52, piloted by Major King Kong (memorably played by Slim Pickens), receives the go-code and attacks the Soviet Union.

As the blockade came into effect at 10.00 am EDT on Wednesday 24 October, the Strategic Air Command moved to DEFCON-2. SAC was responsible for all ICBMs and long-range bombers. Declaration of DEFCON-2 was an unprecedented and unrepeated action during the Cold War. It meant that 1,436 B-47s, B-52s, and B-58s were capable of becoming airborne within fifteen minutes. By early November the number of alerted ICBMs rose from 112 to 182. The first of the new generation of Minuteman ICBMs were designated with an Emergency Combat Capability and placed on operational alert. And by the height of the crisis, the nine Polaris SSBNs were on station, each equipped with sixteen Polaris SLBMs, making a total of 144 missiles.

RAF Bomber Command also raised its state of readiness. Normally, some forty Thor IRBMs were kept at fifteen-minutes readiness. At the height of the missile crisis, fifty-nine Thors could be fired in less than fifteen minutes (as could thirty-seven of the forty-five Jupiter IRBMs in Italy and Turkey).[14] The Alert Condition of the RAF's 120 or so available Victor, Valiant and Vulcan medium-range nuclear bombers was also raised. Normally, each squadron kept one of its bombers on Quick Reaction Alert (QRA), able to become airborne within fifteen minutes (for reasons of cost, the British had not developed an airborne alerting system). Likewise, NATO normally kept a portion of its aircraft on QRA.

On 27 October 1962 Bomber Command moved to Alert Condition 3 (with the maximum number of aircraft made combat ready and prepared for operational take-off). Prime Minister Macmillan was, nevertheless, against 'overt' preparations and so the V-force remained on its main bases and did not deploy to its thirty-six dispersal airfields. However, for several hours on